

CHAVÍN



FROM THE 10TH to the 1st centuries BC, a brilliant civilization flourished in Peru. It is known today as Chavín, after the important town of Chavín de Huántar in central Peru. Its people produced large temples, fine textiles, and created religious art in a distinctive style. They were also the first people to unify the flat coastal region of Peru with the high Andes Mountains beyond. By doing this, they prepared the way for other important Peruvian civilizations, such as the Incas.

Art

Chavín art was highly elaborate. Chavín artists made carved stone reliefs, statuettes in precious metals, and beautiful textiles, some of which have survived. Their favourite subjects were gods and goddesses, and the priests, birds, and animals that attended them. Many works of art, such as the textiles and gold statuettes, were small and easily portable. They were traded far and wide in South America, and later cultures copied their styles.



Kenning

Chavín sculptors liked to use the kenning, a type of visual pun, to represent parts of the body. Instead of carving a person's face realistically, they made up their features using repeated elements such as eyes or snakes. Many Chavín carvings, like this stone relief of a god, are therefore intriguing but difficult to understand.

Jaguar vessel



Animal-figure bowl



Pottery vessel

Andean peoples, such as the Chavín, made highly decorated pottery vessels with tall, curved handles. This example, from Chavín de Huántar, has the face of a jaguar god with a gold nose ornament and large, dangling earrings.

Ornate bowl

This bowl in the shape of an animal is another example of the skill of the Chavín potters' art. It may have been used in a religious ceremony, or adorned the table of a wealthy member of the Chavín nobility.



Civilizations

Other cultures, such as the Chimú, grew up in the Andes region after the Chavín declined.



Castillo

The people of Chavín de Huántar built stone temples at the centre of their city. The famous Old Temple or Castillo was a complex stone structure, containing many intricate passages. Some of these were probably drainage ducts, designed to channel away water from the temple. The adjoining rooms may have been storerooms for offerings and religious equipment.

Chavín de Huántar

The main city of the Chavín civilization was built at a natural transport interchange. It lay on the Mosna River next to two passes into the mountains. The city was therefore well placed for trade, with food such as chillies and salt coming down to the city through the mountain passes.

Religion

The Chavín people had several gods, including a creature called El Lanzón, or "the smiling god". His statue was placed in a central room in the temple at Chavín de Huántar. Above the statue was a hole. A hidden person could speak through this hole, giving the impression that the god himself was speaking.



The staff god

Another important Chavín deity is known as the staff god. This figure is shown in carved reliefs waving a long staff. He was often shown with crops such as manioc, gourds, and peppers, and was thought to be the provider and protector of these valuable foodstuffs.

God carries shield with cross design in his left hand.

El Lanzón

This was probably the main god of the Old Temple. Its statue is found in one of the innermost rooms in the building. It was a human figure that had cat-like teeth, suggesting that it was part-human, part-jaguar, like many ancient gods of South and Central America.

God carries staff in his right hand.

After the Chavín

Several civilizations dominated the Andes after Chavín declined. Tiahuanaco, another highland culture, and their neighbours the Huari, flourished from AD 500 to 900. On the coast, the Chimú were the dominant people from the 10th to 15th centuries, until they were conquered by the Incas.

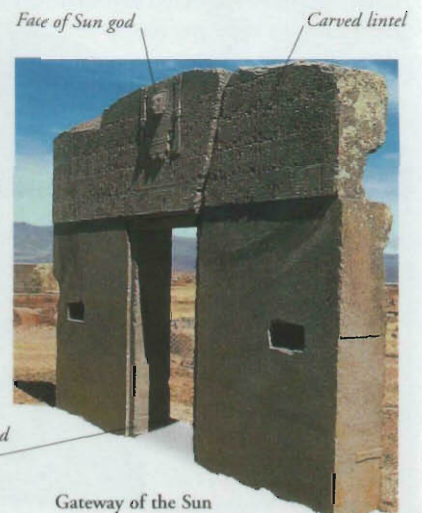


Vessel from Tiahuanaco

Tiahuanaco

This highland empire was a strong, centralized state based in a city on a high plain some 4,000 m (13,100 ft) above sea-level. Its monuments included the Gateway of the Sun, which was carved out of a single block of stone.

Typical square-headed opening



Gateway of the Sun

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